

Trial by Fire: The VFX of The Lost Bus

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Figure 1: Trial by Fire: The VFX of The Lost Bus

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1 Overview

In this Production Session, beloFX takes audiences inside the making of the Oscar-nominated visual effects of *The Lost Bus*, where



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real-time workflows, large-scale simulation, and cinematic storytelling came together.

Built around director Paul Greengrass' visceral handheld style, the film demanded an immersive and grounded approach to recreating California's devastating 2018 Camp Fire. Using Unreal Engine, the team developed a largescale "digital twin" of Northern California for previs, virtual scouting, and production planning, while game-inspired workflows powered everything from dense traffic simulations to reactive handheld camera movement.

The session will explore how these real-time systems helped the production rapidly adapt when several sequences unexpectedly shifted into full CG midway through filming due to real world wildfires. Attendees will gain insight into scalable previs, resilient pipelines, and the evolving role of game-engine technology in modern VFX filmmaking.